

***Instructions, Assessments, and Other
Important Information about
Establishing a Time-Sharing Plan***

**12th Judicial Circuit
Manatee, Sarasota, DeSoto Counties
Florida**

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A Planning Guide for Parents Living Apart

One size does not fit all!

INTRODUCTION

One of the most difficult challenges facing parents at the time of separation is deciding how they will address issues concerning their children. Each family is different. However, putting the best interest of our children must come first. Ending the parents' relationship with each other is NOT the end of their child-parent relationship. Parents often do not realize how much parental conflict hurts children. Children are entitled to the love of both parents, regardless of the differences between the adults in their lives.

HONESTLY RECOGNIZING YOUR FAMILY'S SITUATION AND
YOUR ABSOLUTE RESPONSIBILITY TO
ALWAYS PUT YOUR CHILDREN FIRST
IS CRUCIAL FOR DEVELOPING A PARENTING PLAN.

There is no single standard or even an "ideal" parenting arrangement. It is beyond the ability of this guide to offer customized recommendations for every family. This information is intended to make you think, reflect, discuss, plan and to help you develop a collaborative parenting plan for your children's healthy future. Parents should continue to use this information as a reference as your children grow and your situations change. Tip: Find a picture of your child and complete this with them in mind. Try to keep in mind what will work best for the child, not what YOU want for the child.

**This assessment and all other information included about
childrearing with your child's other parent is suggested as a
helpful tool and is not intended to be used as evidence in court.**

WHAT EXACTLY IS COPARENTING?

COPARENTING means **ADULTS**

- **Communicating**
- **Cooperating**
- **Working Together**

When parents separate, their options for raising their children are: coparenting, parallel parenting or conflict. Coparenting is simply sharing responsibility and raising children **TOGETHER**. It is cooperating in all matters pertaining to a child to promote the **best interests** of the child and not with a view toward the personal desires of the parent. When parents are functioning effectively, coparenting helps to **promote** healthy emotional growth of infants, children, and teenagers. But when coparenting is problematic, children suffer the consequences.

Children adjust better in all aspects of their lives – academically, socially, behaviorally and emotionally, when their parents communicate, coordinate with one another, and cooperate together in their roles as the children's coparents. Conversely, when parents criticize and undermine one another and/or involve their children in adult conflicts, children's adjustment suffers. While this is true for all children, cooperative coparenting is especially important for children whose parents are separated. It is important to keep negative feelings about the other parent away from children. Post-separation parents do best having an agreed-upon plan of **communication** and **coordination** they can both use. Effective coparents understand that in order for the child to continue to develop an independent meaningful relationship with both parents, the parents have to communicate and cooperate with respect. They understand that their work schedules, special events, and extracurricular activities of the child may create occasions when flexibility is necessary. Healthy coparenting allows the parents to make good faith adjustments to any parenting arrangement because it is good for the child.

The most common threats to positive coparenting in are:

- Fighting with one another in front of the children – and worst of all, fighting **ABOUT** the children;
- Bad-mouthing one another to the children, or allowing another person to do so;
- Ignoring, over-ruling or mocking rules set and enforced by the other parent,
- Having the child act as a go-between instead of dealing with adult business between one another -- out of children's earshot; and/or
- Treating the child as an ally and confidante against the other parent and asking the child to keep secrets from the other parent.

Parallel Parenting

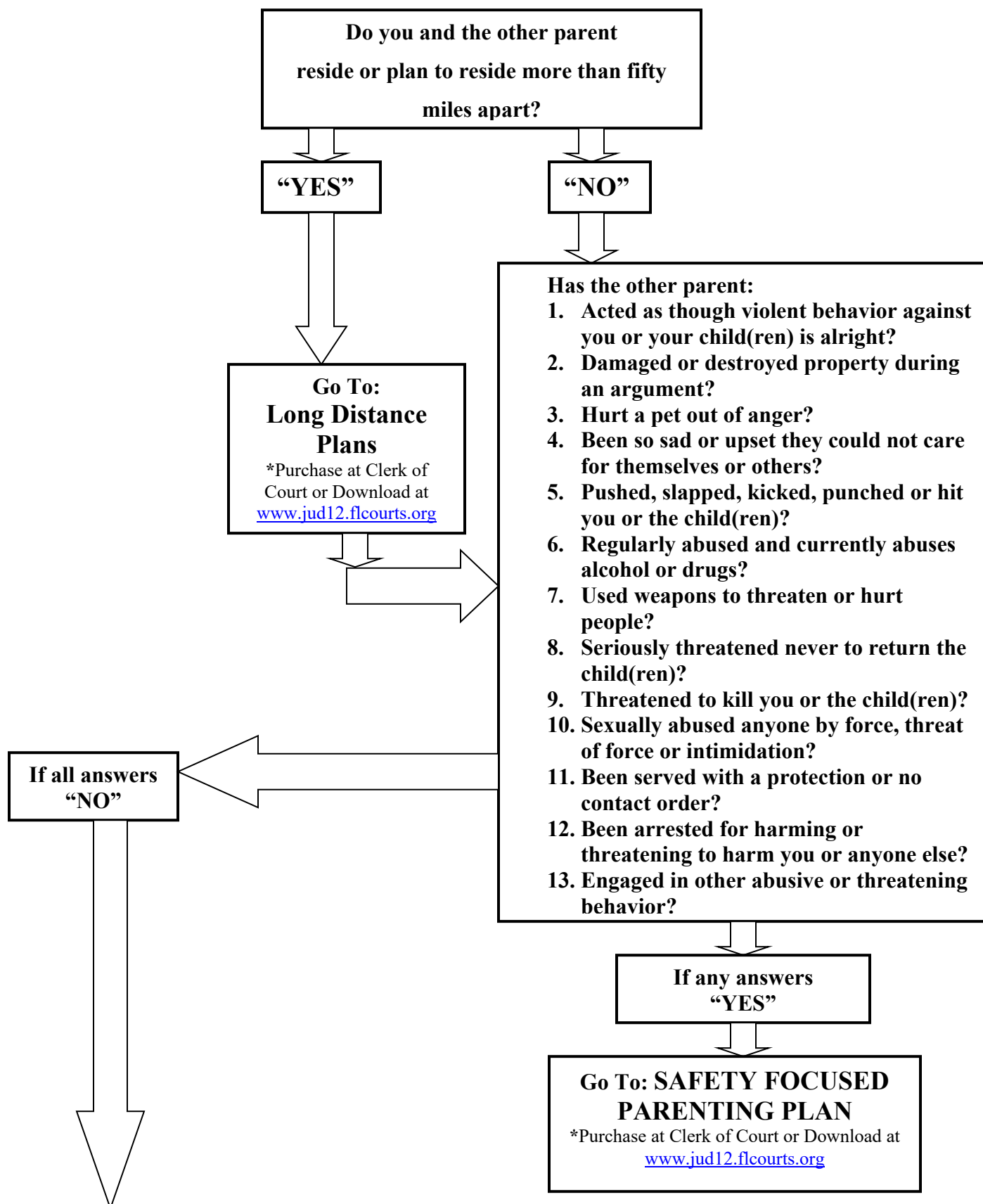
Children thrive most with strong, healthy relationships with both parents. Health relationships may best be achieved through parallel parenting if the parents' relationship is too conflictual with each other. High conflict between parents will negatively impact the children. Parallel parenting allows parents to disengage from one another, thus creating an opportunity for each parent to parent the child effectively when they are together.

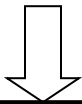
Parallel Parenting:

- Disengaging from conflict with the other parent to lessen tension, particularly in front of children
- Communicating through written means, not through the child(ren). i.e. electronic communication, text
- Both parenting focusing on raising the child(ren) together
- Parents may choose to separate tasks, instead of doing them together. For example, one parent handles educational needs and the other does extra-curricular requirements
- Protects child(ren) from parents unresolved conflict
- Best choice for high conflict families
- Exchanges at school/day care

While some families may start with parallel parenting, they may find that with time and practice disengaging from conflict, they are able to transition to coparenting. It is important to remember that often children state that they do not want to go to the other parent's home simply due to the fact that it is a change and they can sense the parental stress. This is not an indication for parents to keep fighting over time with their children, but rather a chance to re-evaluate each child's relationship with both parents and the parents' relationship with each other.

**QUICK VIEW CHART:
WHICH PARENTING PLAN IS RIGHT
FOR MY FAMILY?**





1. I only communicate with my child(ren)'s other parent by: using email; text message, certified U.S. mail; a third party (lawyer, relative, faith based professional etc.); our child(ren). (Please don't answer yes if this is caused solely by living far apart).
2. I do not believe my child(ren)'s other parent is a good parent.
3. I do not trust my child(ren)'s other parent to consistently use good judgment and make good decisions regarding our child.
4. I keep written and/or recorded records of all contact between myself and my child(ren)'s other parent.
5. I feel it is okay to make all major decisions about my child(ren) without consulting the other parent, because I have our child(ren)'s best interest at heart.
6. My child(ren)'s other parent and I can only exchange our child(ren): in a public setting; with an adult third party present; with the police present; and/or, by maintaining a safe physical distance.
7. Because of my child(ren)'s other parent's actions, I have serious concerns regarding our child(ren)'s emotional and psychological functioning; peer or social relations; mother/child(ren) relationship; father/child(ren) relationship; school performance; behavior; and/or physical health.

**If any answers
"YES"**

**Go To: HIGHLY STRUCTURED
PARENTING PLANS**

*Purchase at Clerk of Court or Download at
www.jud12.flcourts.org

**If all answers
"NO"**

**Go To: BASIC
PARENTING PLANS**

*Purchase at Clerk of Court or Download at
www.jud12.flcourts.org

**may require adjustment from long distance
plan A or B

THESE QUESTIONS WILL HELP YOU RECOGNIZE YOUR ABILITIES AND NEEDS.

SELF-ASSESSMENT:

DAILY SCHEDULE

If you are employed outside the home: What time do you leave? _____ return? _____

If employed in the home, do you need to be home certain hours? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Can your schedule be changed? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Are there any demands on your time after normal work hours? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Is out-of-town travel required? ☐ Yes ☐ No If yes, how often? _____ How long are you gone? _____

OUTSIDE HELP

Do you have any additional help from other family or friends to care for your child(ren)? ☐ Yes ☐ No If so, describe: _____

Are you a caregiver for anyone other than your child(ren)? ☐ Yes ☐ No

TRANSPORTATION

Do you have reliable transportation? ☐ Yes ☐ No

A valid driver's license? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Do you have any health issues which might affect your driving ability? ☐ Yes ☐ No

PARENTING

In what events or situations does the child(ren):

Ask you for help? _____

Respond to your direction? _____

Not respond to your direction? _____

What do you do well as a parent? _____

What do you have trouble with as a parent? _____

COMMUNICATION

Do you have problems communicating with the other parent? ☐ Yes ☐ No Do you have E-mail access? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Internet access? ☐ Yes ☐ No Cell phone? ☐ Yes ☐ No Text Message? ☐ Yes ☐ No

FAMILY EVENTS

What events or holidays are the most important to you? _____

DISCIPLINE

What kind do you use? i.e. corporal, time out, positive reinforcement _____

What kind works for your child(ren)? _____

CO-PARENT ASSESSMENT:

DAILY SCHEDULE

If the other parent is employed outside the home: What time do they leave? _____ Return? _____

If the other parent is employed in the home, do they need to be home certain hours? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Can their schedule be changed? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Are there any demands on the other parent's time after normal work hours? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Is out-of-town travel required? ☐ Yes ☐ No If yes, how often? _____ How long are they gone? _____

OUTSIDE HELP

Does the other parent have any additional help from other family or friends? ☐ Yes ☐ No If so, describe: _____

Are they a caregiver for anyone other than your child(ren)? ☐ Yes ☐ No

TRANSPORTATION

Does the other parent have reliable transportation? ☐ Yes ☐ No A valid drivers license? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Do they have any health issues that effect their ability to drive? ☐ Yes ☐ No

PARENTING

In what events or situations does the child:

Ask for the other parent's help? _____

Respond to the other parent's direction? _____

Not respond to their direction? _____

What does the other parent do well as a parent? _____

What does the other parent have trouble with as a parent? _____

COMMUNICATION

Does the other parent have problems communicating with you? ☐ Yes ☐ No Does the other parent

Have e-mail? ☐ Yes ☐ No Internet? ☐ Yes ☐ No Cell phone? ☐ Yes ☐ No Text Msg? ☐ Yes ☐ No

FAMILY EVENTS

What events or holidays are important to the other parent? _____

DISCIPLINE

What kind does the other parent use? i.e. corporal, time out, positive reinforcement _____

What kind are works for your child(ren)? _____

CHILD ASSESSMENT:

THESE QUESTIONS ARE WRITTEN TO HELP YOU MAKE CHOICES
THAT FIT THE NEEDS OF YOUR CHILD(REN), AND BOTH PARENTS.

Complete one for each child

FULL NAME OF CHILD: _____

DATE OF BIRTH: _____

1. What is the child's age? _____ School? _____ Grade? _____
2. Has the child experienced any separations or deaths? ☐ Yes ☐ No
If Yes, when? _____ Describe: _____
3. Has the child ever been evaluated/tested and/or diagnosed by a licensed professional with any academic needs, physical disability or emotional disorders? ☐ Yes ☐ No
Evaluated by: _____
Diagnosis: _____ When Diagnosed? _____
If Yes, Treatment plan: _____
Do both parents acknowledge and support the treatment plan? ☐ Yes ☐ No
4. Has this child:
 - a. Changed schools other than for normal progression? ☐ Yes ☐ No
 - b. Been held a grade in school? ☐ Yes ☐ No
 - c. Skipped a grade in school? ☐ Yes ☐ No
 - d. Had difficulty in school? ☐ Yes ☐ No
 - e. Been provided an Individualized Educational Plan (IEP)? ☐ Yes ☐ No
 - f. Been found to be academically gifted? ☐ Yes ☐ No
 - g. Missed _____ days/month on-going school days?
5. How long is the travel time from your home? from your work?
 - a. Child's school? _____
 - b. Tutors? _____
 - c. Sporting activities? _____
 - d. Pediatrician? _____
 - e. Extracurricular activities? _____
 - f. Place of worship? _____
 - g. _____

How long is the travel time	from other parent's home?	from other parent's work?
h. Child's school?	_____	_____
i. Tutors?	_____	_____
j. Sporting activities?	_____	_____

- k. Pediatrician? _____
- l. Extracurricular activities? _____
- m. Place of worship? _____
- n. _____

6. List the activities in which this child **currently** participates and check the days of the week on which these events occur.

_____	☐ Mon	☐ Tues	☐ Wed	☐ Thurs	☐ Fri	☐ Sat	☐ Sun	☐ Monthly
_____	☐ Mon	☐ Tues	☐ Wed	☐ Thurs	☐ Fri	☐ Sat	☐ Sun	☐ Monthly
_____	☐ Mon	☐ Tues	☐ Wed	☐ Thurs	☐ Fri	☐ Sat	☐ Sun	☐ Monthly
_____	☐ Mon	☐ Tues	☐ Wed	☐ Thurs	☐ Fri	☐ Sat	☐ Sun	☐ Monthly
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_____	☐ Mon	☐ Tues	☐ Wed	☐ Thurs	☐ Fri	☐ Sat	☐ Sun	☐ Monthly

7. List any future planned activities:

8. How do you and this child spend time together? When?

BE HONEST ABOUT WHAT IS WORKING NOW. CHILDREN NEED A REGULAR SCHEDULE. **HOWEVER**, THERE ARE OFTEN TIMES WHEN SOMEONE WHO WAS NOT AN ACTIVE PARENT BEFORE THE SEPARATION MAY WISH TO BECOME MORE INVOLVED AFTER SEPARATION. THE INITIAL PLAN SHOULD PROVIDE THAT PARENT ENOUGH TIME TO DEVELOP A CLOSER RELATIONSHIP. REMEMBER THAT YOUR VALUE AS A PARENT IS NOT CONNECTED TO THE AMOUNT OF TIME YOU SPEND WITH YOUR CHILD. YOUR VALUE IS BASED ON WHAT YOU CHOOSE TO DO WITH YOUR CHILD DURING YOUR PARENTING TIME TOGETHER.

IMPORTANT FACTORS TO CONSIDER:

- **MINIMIZE LOSS:** Children experience a series of significant losses as a result of the parents' separation. To a child, parents' separating means losing home, family life, loving parents who care about each other, pets, financial security, familiar schools, friends, and a daily routine. Keeping a picture of the other parent and memories of them in the home can help minimize the sadness felt when not with that parent.
- **MAXIMIZE RELATIONSHIPS:** Encourage all relationships which existed for the children before the separation (parents, grandparents, aunts, uncles, friends, step-siblings, siblings) Your children will keep the feeling of family when they have pleasant, free access to both parents and both extended families. Your child's identity depends on their feeling they belong to both families. When possible share the responsibilities (doctors' appointments, transportation) and the joyous events (holidays, movies, birthday parties). When considering a time sharing arrangement, keep in mind your child's desire to spend time with their half and step siblings and try to help them keep as much contact with these family members as possible.
- **PROTECT YOUR CHILD'S FEELINGS AND SENSE OF WELL BEING:** Reassure your children that they are not responsible for the separation and do not blame the other parent for the separation as this forces a child to "take sides". Avoid confiding in them and sharing details of the adult relationships. While they may want to protect your feelings, they later feel confused and resentful. Children are harmed when they hear one parent say bad things about the other parent.
 - Keep all legal documents out of sight of the children. Do not allow the children to overhear conversations with others about your negative feelings about the other parent or your legal case.
- **INCREASE SECURITY:** Scientific research confirms that children will suffer now and later if they frequently see their parents in conflict. Raised voices, arguing, hateful remarks, and physical altercations are not suitable for a child's viewing. Do not discuss adult issues at the time of transfers or when the child is present.
- **AGE RELATED NEEDS:** Children of different ages need and benefit from different parenting arrangements. Parents should try to be flexible and should try to tailor schedules as much as possible to reflect their child's developmental needs and individual requirements. You can expect that, as your child gets older, you will need to be more flexible and will need to work harder at communicating effectively and compromising fairly with both your child and the other parent. Additionally, you may have multiple children at different stages of development. The needs of the most "vulnerable" child (by development, special needs, etc) should be considered first in time sharing.

DEVELOPMENTAL NEEDS

The following information gives you an idea of what is common or the "norm". It will help you understand what you might expect based on what we know about children. Remember that all children develop differently. They have different strengths and skills and develop at different speeds. A child needs to finish the tasks of one period before he can successfully move on, or emotional and behavioral problems will develop. You need to think about each of your children separately as you build your plan. Also, you should remember to look back at these guides as your children grow. You may want to or need to adjust your plans to meet their changes. Children with special needs may need a plan that deviates from the typical development based needs (see pg. 17).

INFANTS: Birth to 9 Months

When Designing Your Parenting Plan for your Infant, Remember:

- Frequent, repeated contact with each parent is recommended. Contact should provide time for feeding, playing, bathing, soothing, napping, and nighttime sleeping. Both parents must develop the required skills to be good caregivers.
 - The infant is totally dependent on the adults around them while they touch, listen, and observe the world. Things are always changing. Infants learn very quickly. They are completely dependent on their caregivers to protect them and to provide constant attention to their needs. This includes their need for love, nurturing, and attention. They form attachments by consistent, loving responses such as holding, playing, feeding, soothing, and talking.
- Infants should not be away from either parent for more than a few days.
 - When both parents have been actively involved, the child forms an attachment to both parents. Changes and separations from the caregiving parent will cause discomfort and distress because an infant does not have a sense of time. An infant cannot remember the absent caregiver without frequent contact. Short, frequent visits or video chat time will be more beneficial than one longer visit with greater separation in between.
- Parents will need to share their experiences in a way to provide consistency and stability. They must do this in a way that does not expose the child to anger and in a way that is comforting to the infant.
- If an infant's needs are not met, parents may notice that their child cries excessively, refuses food, fails to gain weight, has difficulty sleeping, fails to interact with the environment, or shows other signs of distress in one or both households.

BABY/OLDER INFANT: 9 to 18 Months

When Designing Your Parenting Plan for Your Baby, Remember:

- Each parent should participate in the daily routines including feeding, bathing, putting the child down to sleep, and waking the child up from a nap. This will help the child develop a secure relationship and help both parents master the tasks of caretaking.
- Separations of more than three days may interfere with the child's sense of safety and stability. Work responsibilities must be balanced with the child's need for regular involvement with each parent during the weekdays and shared time of weekends.
 - While they can hold on to a memory of an adult they haven't seen for a day or two, they still may show fear or distress at the time of the next contact and cannot tolerate long separations. Children forget people if they are absent from their presence for too long.
- Each household should follow similar patterns and routines in child care to provide consistency.
 - A consistent routine increases their trust in others and their confidence that all of their needs will be met. They can become anxious if separated from familiar and comfortable surroundings.

TODDLER: 20 to 36 Months

When Designing Your Parenting Plan for Your Toddler, Remember:

- Transitions can be difficult unless both parents have soothing styles and can meet the child's needs for structure and reassurance.
- Parenting must be adjusted to meet the child's needs. Similar ways of handling events will provide a sense of comfort.
- Telephone calls at a regular hour can be a good way to "touch base" for the child and the parent. This keeps the relationship in the present.
 - During separations, the toddler needs reminders that the important people have not disappeared, will return, and continue to love them. Nightly phone calls can be reassuring. Only when the child feels safe and secure can they begin to explore their world.
- A picture of each parent in the child's room along with the "special blanket or teddy" that travels back and forth can be reassuring.
- It is best that overnights be spaced throughout the week.
- If a toddler's needs are not met, parents may notice that their child becomes anxious or irritable. The child may become clingy or excessively aggressive; they may have bad dreams. Sometimes they may be scared during transfers and display behaviors they had already outgrown.

PRE-SCHOOL, EARLY KINDERGARTEN: 36 Months to Age 5 ½

When Designing Your Parenting Plan for the Pre-School and Early Kindergarten Child, Remember:

- Take into consideration your child's personality.
- Each parent should be comfortable helping the child complete daily routines. This includes getting dressed, ready for school, etc.
 - If both parents have been involved in all aspects of care (before the separation) the child may be able to be away from either parent for two or three days. They can begin to understand the idea of a day and a week but do not really understand time yet.
- Participate in the daily routines like feeding, playing, bathing, reading.
- Children begin to notice the ways that the parents relate to each other and will imitate this behavior. This begins to set the stage for their own grown up relationships as well as how they will relate to each parent.
- Transitions between households require positive support to help the child know that everybody is ok and gets along.
- Naps are replaced by quiet time and a change of pace in activities. They need consistency and predictability from the outside helps them calm themselves.
- If the child's needs are not met, parents may observe persistent sleeping and/or eating problems. The child may show long periods of being moody: sadness, withdrawal, crying, anger. The child may refuse to participate in activities.

EARLY SCHOOL: 5 to 9 Years

When Designing a Plan for the Early School Child, Remember:

- A consistent schedule and routine is necessary so that the child can focus on the job of school, friends, and team activities.
- Parents should select activities that match the child's interests and work together to balance these activities with the demands of school.
- Birthday parties and other peer activities will be important and may require some additional transportation and flexibility between parents.
- Provide support for the child's school program by setting a study routine and communicating with the teacher.
- Fewer midweek transitions make it easier for finishing school projects but both parents need to participate fully. Research shows that children with both parents involved in their schooling perform better in school.
- They need to check in and touch base. They want the security of stable patterns in caretaking, and regular contact with each parent, including individual time with each parent.
- If a child's needs aren't met, there may be physical problems (tummy aches), sleep problems, anger, and a return to move childish behaviors (bed wetting, baby talk).

PRE-TEEN: 10 to 12 Years

When Designing a Plan for Your Pre-Teen, Remember:

- Parenting plans must provide frequent, meaningful contact with both parents.
- Pre-Teen children do well with many different options of parenting plans as long as the contact is structured and consistent. When possible, plans should include overnights during the school week and on weekends so that both parents may participate in all aspects of a child's life.
- Schedules can provide longer times away from either parent (up to a week) but must take into consideration the child's activities and school responsibilities.
- Children should be given open telephone access to the other parent and be given privacy for the calls.
- Rules and routine between the households should be as consistent as possible.
- Develop a way to discuss the child's academic and extra-curricular activities without including the child in discussions (journal, email communication, text).
- Children can be consulted about their views and suggestions, but the parents should still make the final decision.
- They may choose to side with one parent over the other. This may change based on the specific issue or the parenting style. They need to be encouraged and given permission to love both parents and understand that the parents' separation matters are not their burden.
- Families need flexibility so the child may have the time required with friends and activities as well as with both parents. Parents need to encourage the move towards independence while providing reasonable and consistent limits and boundaries.
- It is a problem if a pre-teen child loses interest in friends and other relationships and begins to isolate (spending extended times in his room, skipping meals and activities, not going out or not answering the phone). A child working too hard at being "too good" could suggest a high level of internal stress or desire to cover up. If the child begins to take sides or feels the need to take sides with one parent there is greater chance of depression and rebellion. A change in school performance and peer group may indicate some loss of well-being.

TEEN: 13 to 15 Years:

When Writing a Plan for Your Early Teen, Remember:

- Though they may not show it, young adolescents continue to need both the nurturing and the oversight of their parents.
- Children frequently form close relationships with other teachers, adults, peers, and generally regard their relationships with their peers as the most important relationships in their lives. They want to spend much more time with their friends and less time with their parents. There is normally an increase in moodiness, tiredness, and sloppiness.
- The child's schedule, commitments, and obligations must be taken into consideration.
- Flexible creative plans that would not have worked for younger children may be considered.
- While each parent may have a longer period of time without the child in residence, the parent should increase contact and awareness through regular attendance at the child's athletic events, performances, academic events, and other activities.
- The challenge for parents of these early adolescents is to support their growing independence while maintaining basic structure and close contact with both parents. The guidelines must be reasonable, firm, and fair, as should the privileges and consequences. It will be important that the parents talk or communicate directly with each other to be certain that the child is safe and accountable.
- Children are exposed to a variety of situations that put them at risk, and parents must stay informed and able to discuss these hard topics (sexual behaviors, alcohol use, drug abuse).
- Frequent communication between parents is advised as children may distort the situation and seek to play one parent against the other. Consider communicating by using a journal, email, phone calls, texting, or "business like" meeting.
- If the teen's needs are not met, there may be excessive anger and negativity. Children this age may begin to hide out or stay away from others. School difficulties become evident as the demands of school become greater. There will be an increase in the acting out, sometimes with increased sneakiness, lying, and risky behaviors. Out and out defiance of rules is a real concern.

OLDER ADOLESCENT: 15 to 18 Years:

When Designing a Plan for Your Older Adolescent, Remember:

- Adolescents do well with a variety of parenting plans.
- Parents need to be aware of the adolescent's need to be consulted, informed, and involved when making the schedule and making family plans.
- Parenting times and schedules will need to take into consideration school demands, job hours, automobile access, and extra-curricular/social activities.
- Flexibility may be necessary when considering the added costs of auto insurance, education, etc.
- Adolescents need to balance time between independent social time with peers and meaningful family time. By late adolescence, they have begun to view their parents as individuals with qualities they both like and dislike.
- Children are particularly vulnerable to changes in the family and pressure from outside the family. Maintaining stability and consistency can be challenging as an adolescent's feelings are often changeable and intense.

CHILDREN WITH SPECIAL NEEDS

For children with special needs, a typical development based parenting plan may not be the most appropriate. In these cases, the need for consistency and routine outweighs the desire for equal time sharing with each parent. Both parents will need to be knowledgeable about the child's needs, active in the treatment plan and able to follow through with the recommendations provided by the child's health care professionals. The parents will need to be able to share information with each other and establish a clear structure for the child in order to limit the disruptions in the child's life. Once a parenting plan is set, it may need to be reviewed more regularly than a typical parenting plan and information from the child's school, mental and medical health team should be weighed when making revisions.

BLENDED FAMILIES

Special attention must be paid when adding new family members into an already established unit. The potential for conflict and tension in stepparent-stepchildren relationships is high and a positive relationship should be encouraged by both parents. Boundaries should be discussed and established with all adults involved to set clear expectations and prevent negative emotions from clouding parenting decisions. The addition of stepsiblings and half siblings may necessitate a revision to the parenting plan.

IN ALL PLANS IT IS IMPORTANT TO REMEMBER:

- *Children develop best when both parents have meaningful and stable involvement in their children's lives.*
- *Each parent has different and valuable contributions to make to their children's development.*
- *It is better for young children to spend more time with parents and less time with other caregivers. When both parents work, parents should make every attempt to choose mutually-acceptable and accessible caregivers.*
- *Communication and cooperation between parents is important. Consistent rules in both households and sharing of knowledge of events, creates a sense of security for children of all ages. Households must discuss and plan school activities and other events.*
- *If children are allowed to bring their personal items back and forth between the households, they develop a better sense of ownership and responsibility. Parents should purchase special things for the children but not merely for their own household.*
- *Children need to be protected from adult conflicts. They should not be exposed to arguments, hostility, and negative comments between the parents. They do not want to hear negative things about someone they love.*
- *They should not be messengers...they are the children. The parents should do the adult work so that children may complete the tasks of being children.*

The Do's and Don'ts of Parenting

Both Parents

DO:

- Maintain healthy communication with your children.
- Make it a priority to communicate regularly with the other parent.
- Religiously follow the parenting plan to make the process routine, easy, and positive for your children.
- Strive to keep your word to the children.
- Contact the other parent immediately if there is an emergency involving the children while they are with you.

DON'T:

- Be uncooperative. The children will suffer consequences if their parents do not cooperate.

Parent A

(The parent with whom the child has more time-sharing)

DO:

- Share information about school, teachers, activities, friends and relatives with the other parent.
- Be flexible and supportive of the children's relationship with the other parent.
- Encourage excitement for the anticipated communication and/or travel with the other parent.

DON'T:

- Edit, coach, monitor, or otherwise interfere with the children's communication with the other parent.
- Take it personally if the children do not wish to call you regularly when they are with the other parent.

Parent B

(The parent with whom the child has less scheduled time-sharing)

DO:

- Make an extra effort to initiate contact with the children and educate yourself of their daily activities.
- Provide an itinerary to the other parent to prepare the children for the trip and to advise the other parent of the activities you are planning.
- Strive to keep your word to the children.

DON'T:

- Take it personally if the children do not wish to stay on the phone too long or do not call right back.
- Don't unreasonably limit the children's contact with the local parent during their stay.

REMEMBER

As you develop your parenting plan
Focus on your child(ren)'s needs and...

BE HONEST! Think about your child(ren)'s ages, personalities, their likes and dislikes, interests, activities, ability to talk to the other parent, etc. Each family is different. There is no single parenting plan that is right for every family. Each parent will be asked to define a schedule that works best for your child(ren).

THIS IS YOUR CHANCE TO CREATE A SCHEDULE THAT WORKS FOR YOUR CHILD(REN). REMEMBER YOUR PARENTING SCHEDULE MAY CHANGE AS YOUR CHILD(REN) GROW.

REVIEW YOUR PARENTING PLAN WHEN:

- * a child starts school
- * a child's schedule changes
- * a parent remarries
- * anyone experiences any major change